

MFA • Course overview for staff and students

Game Production

“What is unique to games and game design?”

Exploring what games are and what games can do — game design as a means of enquiry, artistic expression and intervention into complex phenomena in society.

16

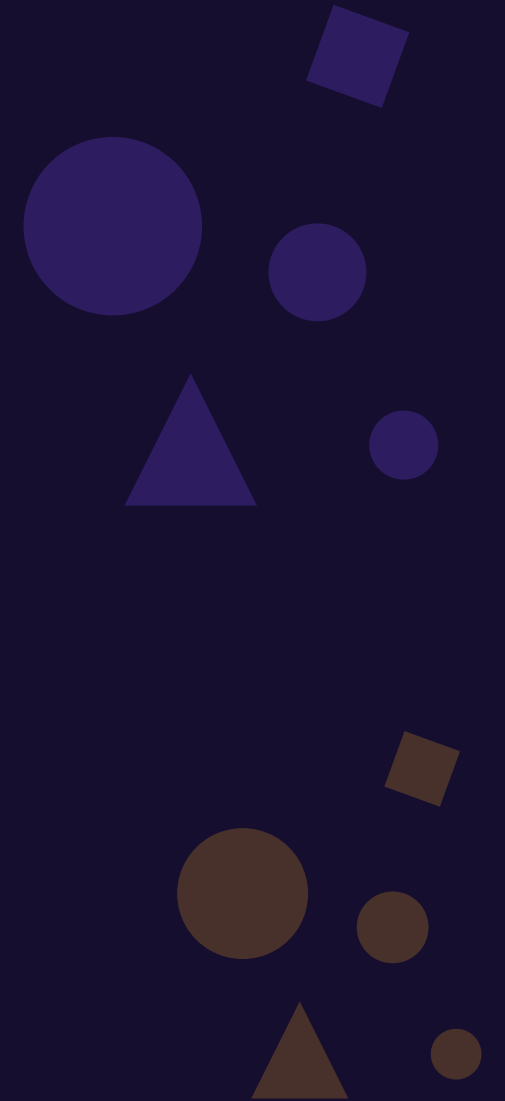
teaching weeks,
plus week 1 of 2027

4

Samlinger
(intensive gatherings)

2

contact days
every week



The aim of the course

To explore the capability of games and game production, and to fully explore the possibility space — using game design as a means of enquiry and of understanding complex phenomena. This is done through hands-on production in teams, targeted towards artistic expression, intervention and enquiry.

The possibility space includes



Artistic games

Games as an artistic medium and material for expression.



Entertainment games

The craft of designed play and engaging experience.



Serious games

Modelling and examining complex systems and societal challenges.



Games that make claims

Works that state, argue, or re-position players to new vantage points.



Students work together in production teams throughout the course.

Six teaching forms

Input, application and feedback are delivered through six distinct formats that run in parallel across the course.



Lectures

Tuesdays 13–16

Theory input: game design, game studies, game theory, system dynamics and narratology.



Workshops

Tuesdays 13–16

Hands-on method work: causal loop diagrams, mechanics, world building and pipelines.



Group supervision

Wednesdays 9–12

Production teams meet supervisors on their ongoing project work.



Consultations

Wednesdays 9–12

Targeted specialist input in specific areas, as needed throughout the productions.



Studio visits

Wednesdays 9–12

Incremental feedback from specialists across different areas of game design and art.



Samlinger

Weeks 1, 6, 12 & 15

Four intensive gatherings that punctuate and re-frame the course.

The weekly rhythm

Two contact days a week: one for input, one for response.

Tuesday

13:00 – 16:00

- Lectures
- Workshops

Shared theoretical and methodological input for the whole cohort.

Wednesday

09:00 – 12:00

- Consultations
- Supervisions
- Studio visits

Team-by-team response, specialist advice and incremental feedback.



Between the contact days: team production work — research, world building, prototyping, play-testing.

Two tracks, running in parallel

Every week pairs a teaching component with a matching focus for the production teams. What is taught on Tuesday is put to work in the project.



Teaching component

Concepts, theory and method — delivered to the whole cohort

week
by week



Student group-work focus

The same material applied inside each team's own production

week
by week



Production teams

Students work together in teams for the whole course — planning, building and presenting one production.



Peer-to-peer review

Week 10: teams analyse and review each other's games, using shared analytical vocabulary.

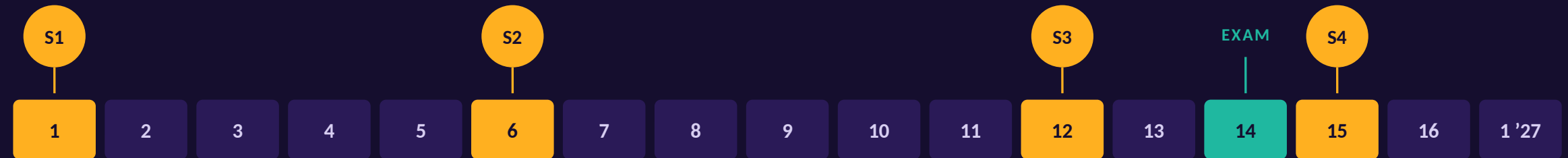


Play-testing

Weeks 13–14: research methods, play-throughs and structured testing with participants.

The course at a glance

Course weeks 1–16 correspond to calendar weeks 36–51 of 2026, continuing into week 1 of 2027.



COURSE WEEK

ENQUIRY

GREEN-LIGHT

TEST

REFLECT

Games, systems and society

Game design, game studies and system dynamics. Narrative structure, causal loop diagrams and the societal challenge each team will work with.

Design and production start

Project pitch and green-lighting. World building, pipelines and tools. The “gears of the game”: rules, mechanics, affordances and artistic intentionality.

Analysis, prototypes, play-testing

Game analysis and peer-to-peer review. Prototypes and the communication of the gears. Research methods, play-throughs and testing. Exam in week 14.

Peeling the onion

Samling 4 on play and the structure of games, then reflection on the layers of production and the resulting experience.

 Samling (intensive gathering)

 Exam week

01

ENQUIRY · Games, systems and society

Course weeks 1–5 · calendar weeks 36–40

WEEK

TEACHING COMPONENT

STUDENT GROUP-WORK FOCUS

1

cal. 36

● SAMLING 1 — Introduction

● SAMLING 1 — Introduction

2

cal. 37

- Introduction to game design, game studies, game theory and system dynamics.

- Exploring themes and societal challenges that can be represented, examined or modelled with game design or other participatory media.

3

cal. 38

- Experience through narrative structure. Narratology as experience design: multilayered, sequential and spatial arrangement. Myths, patterns and formats.

- Societal challenge review, representation and enactment. Big stories across time and culture.

4

cal. 39

- System thinking and system design. Causality of action; systems as gestalts of underlying patterns with multiple agentic actors pursuing multiple “win states”.

- Causal loop diagrams (CLDs): restructuring simple game ideas into CLDs for review, de-construction and re-construction.

5

cal. 40

- System dynamics operating in society. “Tragedy of the commons”; systemic versus agentic win-states.

- Societal patterns and challenges combined with “big stories”. Re-examining win states over the short and long term, in and beyond the game. Story as mirroring structure.

02

GREEN-LIGHT · Design decisions and production start

Course weeks 6–9 · calendar weeks 41–44

WEEK

TEACHING COMPONENT

STUDENT GROUP-WORK FOCUS

6

cal. 41

● SAMLING 2

● SAMLING 2

7

cal. 42

● World building and game production. Methods and pipelines: GitHub, Unreal, Unity.

● Project planning and project pitch (green-lighting).

8

cal. 43

● Rules, mechanics and affordances — the gears of a game and the creation of an agentic experience. The working components of game play and of participatory art forms that structure the actions of others.

● Refining the “gears of the game”: rules, mechanics and affordances tuned to the desired experiential outcomes for their players and participants.

9

cal. 44

● Artistic intentionality. Managing hierarchies of importance in relation to artistic goals, visions and intentions; defining the desired experience for the player.

● Game play, rules, mechanics and affordances as experiential structures. Artistic intention in relation to context and participant experience.

03

TEST · Analysis, prototypes and play-testing

Course weeks 10–14 · calendar weeks 45–49

WEEK

TEACHING COMPONENT

STUDENT GROUP-WORK FOCUS

10

cal. 45

- Game analysis.

- Game reviews: game analysis, peer to peer.

11

cal. 46

- Review of student works; continuation of weeks 4, 8 and 9.

- Prototypes and the communication of the “gears of the game”.

12

cal. 47

- **SAMLING 3**

- **SAMLING 3**

13

cal. 48

- Research methods and play-testing I. Play-throughs and testing I.

— not specified in the course description —

14

cal. 49 · EXAM

- Research methods and play-testing II. Play-throughs and testing II.

— not specified in the course description —

04

REFLECT · Peeling the onion

Course weeks 15–16 · calendar weeks 50–51 · and week 1 / 2027

WEEK

TEACHING COMPONENT

STUDENT GROUP-WORK FOCUS

15

cal. 50

- SAMLING 4 — “The phenomena of play and the structure of games”

- SAMLING 4

16

cal. 51

- “Peeling the onion”: reflecting on the multiple layers of production and experience.

- Reflection on the correlations between the layers of production and the resulting experience, in relation to artistic intentions.

1 '27

cal. 01

- Continued: “peeling the onion”. How to tell a story / forge / enact / transfer / structure. Review of the “gears of the game”.

— not specified in the course description —



Weeks 15–16 close 2026; teaching resumes in week 1 of 2027 to complete the reflection.

Calendar · September – October 2026

Every teaching day from the start of the course. Tuesdays 13–16, Wednesdays 9–12.

September 2026

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
wk 36 course wk 1		1 Samling 1 · Introduction	2 Samling 1 · Introduction	3	4	5	6
wk 37 course wk 2	7	8 Game design & game studies	9 Themes & societal challenges	10	11	12	13
wk 38 course wk 3	14	15 Narrative structure	16 Challenge review · big stories	17	18	19	20
wk 39 course wk 4	21	22 System thinking & system design	23 Causal loop diagrams	24	25	26	27
wk 40 course wk 5	28	29 System dynamics in society	30 Win states & big stories				

October 2026

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
wk 40				1	2	3	4
wk 41 course wk 6	5	6 Samling 2	7 Samling 2	8	9	10	11
wk 42 course wk 7	12	13 World building & pipelines	14 Project pitch · green-lighting	15	16	17	18
wk 43 course wk 8	19	20 Rules & mechanics	21 Refining the gears of the game	22	23	24	25
wk 44 course wk 9	26	27 Artistic intentionality	28 Artistic intention in context	29	30	31	

 Samling

 Tuesday · lectures & workshops

 Wednesday · consultations, supervisions & studio visits

Calendar · November – December 2026

Exam week falls in calendar week 49 (30 November – 6 December).

November 2026

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
wk 44							1
wk 45 course wk 10	2	3 Game analysis	4 Peer-to-peer game reviews	5	6	7	8
wk 46 course wk 11	9	10 Review of student works	11 Prototypes & the gears	12	13	14	15
wk 47 course wk 12	16	17 Samling 3	18 Samling 3	19	20	21	22
wk 48 course wk 13	23	24 Research methods & play-testing I	25 Play-throughs & testing I	26	27	28	29
wk 49	30						

December 2026

	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
wk 49 course 14 · exam		1 Research methods & play-testing II	2 Play-throughs & testing II	3	4	5	6
wk 50 course wk 15	7	8 Samling 4 · Play & structure	9 Samling 4	10	11	12	13
wk 51 course wk 16	14	15 Peeling the onion	16 Layers & artistic intention	17	18	19	20
wk 52 break	21	22	23	24	25	26	27
wk 53 break	28	29	30	31			

21 December – 3 January is a break (weeks 52–53). Teaching resumes on Tuesday 5 January 2027.

The four Samlinger

Intensive gatherings that open, re-frame and close each stage of the course.

1

Week 1 • cal. 36

Introduction

Opens the course and the shared frame of enquiry.

2

Week 6 • cal. 41

Toward production

Sits directly before green-lighting and the production start.

3

Week 12 • cal. 47

Toward testing

Sits before the research-methods and play-testing weeks.

4

Week 15 • cal. 50

Play and structure

Re-frames the whole course through play as a creative driver.

SAMLING 4 — DRAFT DESCRIPTION

“The phenomena of play and the structure of games”

- Play and game-like structures as creative tools.
- Fundamentals of ecological psychology (affordances) and the development of perception through evolution.
- Play not as a result of culture but as a central driver in evolution and in culture — and how that relates to working creatively today.
- Play versus games; narrative structures compared in linear and non-linear formats.
- Narrative as predetermined gestalt (stories, plays, films) versus emergent generative structure — combinations of affordances producing non-predetermined outcomes.

Literature

A starting list, grouped by what each cluster contributes — further titles to be added.

1 Play & culture

Play as a cultural form, and the frames that hold social interaction together.

- Johan Huizinga
- Brian Sutton-Smith
- Erving Goffman

2 Development & learning

Play in cognitive development — how learning happens through doing.

- Lev Vygotsky
- Jean Piaget

3 Perception & affordance

Direct perception and affordances — the ground under weeks 8 and 15.

- James J. Gibson

4 Game design practice

Method, narrative and iteration: designing play as a working practice.

- Tracy Fullerton
- Janet H. Murray
- Jane McGonigal
- Hwiller

5 Artistic practice & aesthetics

Experience, attention and imagination as the material of artistic work.

- John Dewey
- Maxine Greene
- Torkil Færø



More to come

The reading list is open — further titles will be added as the productions, consultations and studio visits develop.

In summary

One production, four phases, six ways of teaching it.



● Enquiry first

Teams begin from a societal challenge or theme, examined through systems and story before anything is built.

● Production in teams

One shared production runs the length of the course, green-lit in week 7 and tested in weeks 13–14.

● Feedback at every scale

Lectures and workshops for the cohort, supervision and consultations for the team, studio visits for the work itself.

● Reflection as method

The course closes by peeling the onion — reading the finished experience back against the artistic intention.